

Ultimate Nutrition

GABA

Gamma-aminobutyric acid, abbreviated as GABA, is an amino acid that is produced in the brain. It is formed by glutamic acid in the body with the help of vitamin B6, and prevents nerve cells from firing too much and, thus, they have a calming effect. As such, GABA serves as a neurotransmitter.

In the body, GABA is found in large amounts in the hypothalamus suggesting that this amino acid plays a crucial role in the hypothalamic-pituitary function. The hypothalamus is a region on the back of the brain, which regulates the instinctive functions, such as sleep cycles, body temperature and the activity of the pituitary gland. The pituitary is the master endocrine gland that affects all hormonal functions of the body. One primary hormone produced in and secreted by the pituitary is growth hormone, which is of great interest to the athlete. GABA is an excellent substitute for growth hormone or "stacking" with other amino acids and nutrients to give more strength and afford faster recovery after intense exercise.

Several clinical studies have shown that ingestion of GABA releases growth hormone, especially after exercise, with remarkable effectiveness. Release of growth hormone increases lean body mass. Consequently, it is an invaluable nutritional supplement for body builders, powerlifters, runners, martial artists, and other athletes of all shades.

In addition, because of its calming and soothing effects, GABA also lowers blood pressure, helps control hypoglycemia, prevents anxiety and promotes restful sleep. To an extent, it also regulates appetite, which is helpful in maintaining optimal weight.

GABA is best taken before going to sleep on a relatively empty stomach. Empty stomach means approximately 45 minutes after the ingestion of the day's last meal. Intake of GABA at bed time makes it work with the body's natural rhythms for increased growth hormone production, which happens roughly 90 minutes after the onset of sleep. The evening intake of GABA correlates with GABA's effect to induce restful and refreshing sleep.

Even though the effect of GABA varies from individual to individual, the beneficial effects may be discernible within two weeks, but its full impact may be noticed after six to eight weeks.

Thus, GABA packs a great deal of punch in one amino acid that has numerous beneficial effects, and promotes general wellbeing relatively quickly.

SELECTED REFERENCES

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FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

1. What Does GABA Taste Like?

GABA is an amino acid: Its taste can be described as somewhat medicinal or chemical, because the Ultimate Nutrition product does not contain any adulterating flavors or fillers.

2. Can GABA Be Mixed with a Protein Drink?

GABA can be taken with any other supplement, but not at the same time. Since it is a single amino acid, its absorption will be maximized in a "noncompetitive" environment, which will yield better results. Since GABA is ordinarily taken at the bedtime, this should not be a problem.

3. Are There Any Side Effects Associated with GABA?

Some people have reported tingling on the surface of the skin for a few minutes after the intake of GABA. This may be likened to the well-known "niacin flush." GABA may also induce a slight shortness of breath, which is also transient and is experienced by a small percentage of people.

Rather rarely, both these sensations may be experienced by a small percentage of people, but they are temporary, and resolve of their own accord. It should be noted that GABA has a slight sedative effect and causes drowsiness. Therefore, it should be taken right before retiring for the day.